EDENBRIDGE GRAMMAR
BEYOND SCHOOLING

Edenbridge Grammar

Teaching and Learning Policy

Powered by U_Connect | ExelAcademy (Human-Led, AI-Enhanced Learning)

This Teaching and Learning Policy sets out the educational approach of Edenbridge Grammar. The framework is informed by and adopted from Tirzah Elese's ExelAcademy teaching and learning model, recognised for its human-led, AI-enhanced approach to learning. It has been thoughtfully adapted and contextualised to reflect the values, vision, and educational priorities of Edenbridge Grammar, ensuring alignment with the school's community, learners, and long-term goals.

This document outlines our future-facing model that combines academic mastery with applied, challenge-driven learning, grounded in Islamic character and a strong sense of Essential Belonging.

At Edenbridge Grammar, teachers make Islamic values visible in daily practice through:

• Intention (niyyah): beginning learning with purpose, reflection, and respectful routines.

• Adab (beautiful conduct): modelling kindness, humility, gratitude, and responsibility in every interaction.

• Ihsan (excellence): valuing quality of effort, craftsmanship, and character; not only outcomes.

• Amanah (trust): honest work, ethical use of technology, and care for others' rights and dignity.

• Ukhuwwah (brotherhood/sisterhood): building collaboration, service, and repair of relationships.

• Khidmah (service): connecting learning to contribution for family, community, and wider society.

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Edenbridge Grammar Teaching and Learning Policy

Purpose

This policy explains how teaching and learning work at Edenbridge Grammar. It is written to support teachers, school leaders, and families in understanding what learning looks like in practice, not just in theory.

The policy does not prescribe a single teaching style. Instead, it explains the shared approach that guides lesson design, classroom culture, and interactions between teachers and students.

Below is a breakdown of all the expectations of the Teaching Staff at Edenbridge Grammar

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Essential Belonging, Learner Diversity, and Individual Pathways

At Edenbridge Grammar, we move beyond the concept of inclusion toward a culture of **essential belonging**. Every learner is recognised as an integral and valued part of the learning community, not because they are accommodated, but because of the unique perspectives, strengths, and ways of thinking they bring.

Essential belonging means that learners come to understand that they matter to the community *because of who they are*, how they think, how they learn, and how they contribute alongside others. Difference is not viewed as something to manage or compensate for, but as a source of richness that strengthens collective learning.

Learning at Edenbridge Grammar is intentionally designed to honour this principle. Flexible pacing, multiple pathways, applied learning, and varied forms of expression allow learners to engage with knowledge in ways that align with their cognitive profiles, interests, and readiness. Understanding may be demonstrated through dialogue, making, writing, design, collaboration, leadership, or problem-solving, ensuring that learning is not confined to a single mode or measure.

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Teachers are expected to:

- recognise and value diverse ways of thinking and learning
- design learning that allows different strengths to emerge
- maintain high expectations for all learners
- support each student to recognise their own contribution to the community
- help learners understand how their abilities complement those of others

Through this approach, learners develop not only academic capability, but a deep sense of self-belief, confidence, and responsibility. They learn that they are essential members of a shared learning endeavour, and that growth occurs through learning *with* and *from* one another.

Essential belonging is therefore not an additional strategy or policy. It is a foundational condition for learning at Edenbridge Grammar, shaping how learning is designed, how relationships are formed, and how every learner is supported to thrive.

Learning Culture, Relationships, and Intellectual Safety

Learning Culture, Relationships, and Intellectual Safety

The quality of learning at Edenbridge Grammar is shaped not only by curriculum and pedagogy, but by the culture of relationships within learning spaces. Learning is understood as both an intellectual and moral endeavour, grounded in intention, respect, and responsibility.

Edenbridge Grammar learning environments are characterised by:

- respect for different perspectives, cultures, and ways of thinking
- openness to questioning, uncertainty, and the pursuit of understanding
- encouragement of intellectual risk-taking guided by humility and good conduct
- shared responsibility for learning and contribution to the community
- collaboration grounded in trust, care, and mutual accountability

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Teachers and Experts are responsible for cultivating environments where learners feel safe to think aloud, make mistakes, revise ideas, express their identity, and challenge assumptions respectfully. Learning conversations are guided by **adab** (respectful conduct), ensuring that dialogue, disagreement, and debate are purposeful, thoughtful, and considerate of others.

Students are supported to develop **niyyah** (clear intention) in their learning, understanding that effort, honesty, and integrity matter as much as outcome. Through this approach, curiosity is protected, effort is valued, and challenge is experienced as growth rather than threat.

Learning culture at Edenbridge Grammar reflects a commitment to **amanah** (trust and responsibility) and **ukhuwwah** (community and belonging), ensuring that every learner understands their role in contributing positively to the learning of others. In striving for **ihsan** (excellence), students are encouraged to pursue knowledge with sincerity, discipline, and care for the wider community.

Safeguarding and Ethical Use of Technology in Learning

Edenbridge Grammar's learning model is **human-led and ethically grounded**. While technology and AI tools play an important role in supporting personalisation, feedback, and access to knowledge, responsibility for learning, wellbeing, and safeguarding always remains with adults.

Teachers and Experts retain oversight of:

- how technology is used
- how learners engage with digital tools
- how progress and evidence are interpreted
- how relationships and wellbeing are supported

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AI tools are used transparently, purposefully, and within clearly defined boundaries. They are supervised, monitored, and integrated thoughtfully into learning, never replacing professional judgement, relational teaching, or care.

Safeguarding, data protection, and ethical considerations are treated as foundational to trust and professionalism, ensuring that innovation always serves the best interests of learners.

Our Approach to Teaching and Learning

At Edenbridge Grammar, learning is designed to help students understand ideas deeply, apply what they know, and grow in confidence as learners.

This means that learning is:

Mastery-Focused Rather Than Time-Bound

Students are not expected to move on simply because a lesson or unit has ended. Instead, they progress when they show a clear understanding of key ideas.

In practice, this looks like:

- students revisiting concepts until they make sense
- teachers checking understanding regularly, not only at the end
- allowing some learners to move faster and others to take more time
- valuing depth of understanding over speed or completion

The aim is for students to build strong foundations that support future learning. The programmed AITutor Bot will guide and monitor this, yet it's important for teachers and parents to moderate this regularly and challenge the student to utilise the resource to deeply embed knowledge for long-term learning.

See: **ExelTutor Bot** Back Office Progress Tracking Document

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Inquiry-Led Rather Than Transmission-Based

Learning is not only about receiving information. Students are encouraged to ask questions first, explore ideas, and make connections for themselves, with guidance from the teacher.

As in the words of Dan Rothstein and Luz Santana, presenting their research-informed, practice-focused book 'Make Just One Change', they argue a simple but powerful case:

'If students learn how to ask better questions, they become better thinkers, learners, and citizens.'

At Edenbridge Grammar we make a 360 *Shift* from teachers being the primary questioners to **students learning to ask, improve, and use their own questions**.

This single shift has wide-reaching effects on:

- engagement
- ownership of learning
- depth of understanding
- confidence
- participation and equity

In practice, this looks like:

- Learning sessions that include questioning, discussion, and exploration
- Encouragement to students to engage in group work or interviews with Experts during their AITutor Bot learning sessions
- Teachers, Guides and Experts guiding thinking rather than providing all answers
- Students explaining their reasoning and thinking aloud
- Curiosity being treated as an important part of learning

Teachers still teach directly when needed, but learning is designed to involve active thinking rather than passive listening.

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The Question Formulation Technique (QFT)

At the heart of Edenbridge Grammar's practice is the **Question Formulation Technique (QFT)** - a structured process that teaches students to generate, refine, and use questions to spark their daily engagement, resulting in deeper understanding and long-term learning.

The process typically includes:

1. **A Question Focus**
   A prompt, statement, image, or problem designed to provoke thinking.
2. **Producing Questions**
   Students generate as many questions as possible without judgement or discussion.
3. **Improving Questions**
   Students categorise questions (open / closed), practise changing one type into another, and discuss how question type affects thinking.
4. **Prioritising Questions**
   Students decide which questions are most important or useful for the task or inquiry.
5. **Using Questions**
   Questions are used to guide research, discussion, problem-solving, or reflection.
6. **Reflecting on Learning**
   Students consider how their questions influenced their learning.

The emphasis is not on "getting the right question", but on **developing questioning as a thinking habit**.

Why This Matters for Learning

When students learn to formulate questions:

- thinking becomes more **active and intentional**

- learners **engage more deeply** with content

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- **understanding improves** across subjects
- **quieter students participate more confidently**
- classrooms become more **inclusive and democratic**

Importantly, the technique works across:

- age groups
- subjects
- academic and applied learning
- traditional and innovative settings

Role of the Teacher

In *Make Just One Change* and *"Making Learning Visible"* teaching theories and models, that are embedded in Edenbridge Grammar, the teacher's role shifts from:

questioner or Instructor → facilitator of questioning

Teachers:

- design strong question focuses - (underpinned by Higher Order Questioning, Socratic Questioning or Lateral Thinking techniques)
- hold back from answering too quickly
- create safe conditions for curiosity
- Space to come to the 'wrong answer', try it out, observe the results and understand deeper
- guide students in refining and using questions

This aligns closely with:

- Socratic dialogue
- Blooms Taxonomy and Higher Order Thinking

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- inquiry-based learning
- metacognitive development
- your model of teacher as **thinking partner and guide**

Connection to Critical and Lateral Thinking

Questioning as the **gateway skill** for:

- critical thinking (analysis, evaluation, reasoning)
- lateral thinking (exploring alternatives, reframing problems)
- independent learning

Rather than teaching "critical thinking" as an abstract skill, it embeds it in the **daily habit of questioning**.

A Play and Questioning Learning Partner - HOW?

Responsive to Individual Readiness and Pace

Students develop understanding at different rates. Teaching, mentoring, and guidance at Edenbridge Grammar respond directly to where each learner is, rather than expecting all students to learn in the same way or at the same pace.

Responsiveness looks different depending on the learning context.

Adults are expected to engage fully in 'Active Listening' at all times. Below is a detailed outline of 'What that means'.

Active Listening in Teaching and Learning

Active listening is the disciplined practice of giving full attention to a learner's thinking in order to understand meaning, reasoning, and intention, rather than simply waiting to respond or correct. For teachers, active listening is not passive agreement; it is an intentional stance that supports deeper thinking, confidence, and intellectual growth.

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At Edenbridge Grammar, active listening underpins effective questioning, inquiry, and mentoring. It enables teachers to respond to what students *are actually thinking*, not what they are expected to say.

The Mindset of Active Listening

Active listening begins with a shift in mindset.

Teachers who practise active listening:

- assume that student responses contain meaning, even when they are incomplete or unclear or even completely 'off topic'
- A mindset that holds a deep belief that all students want to be relevant in that situation and that their contribution has intention and meaning to them - we just have to listen long enough to connect to it
- prioritise understanding thinking over judging accuracy
- value process as much as outcome
- recognise that silence and hesitation are part of deep thinking and learning
- see listening as an act of professional skill, not politeness

This mindset requires teachers to temporarily suspend the urge to correct, explain, drive action or evaluate and instead remain curious about how a learner is constructing understanding.

Active Listening in Practice: Teacher Behaviours

Active listening is visible in what teachers *do*.

Teachers demonstrate active listening when they:

- maintain attention through body language, eye contact, and positioning
- allow students to finish ideas without interruption
- paraphrase or reflect back what a student has said to check understanding
- ask follow-up questions that build on student responses rather than redirect them

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- acknowledge uncertainty or partial understanding without dismissing it
- wait before responding, allowing thinking time
- Encourage group discussions and 'student talk' - limiting 'Teaching Talk Time'

For example, instead of saying, *"That's not quite right,"* a teacher might say, *"Tell me more about how you're thinking about this."*

Or rather than shutting a statement down by saying "That comment isn't on topic" ask "What connections did you see between our discussion and your ideas"

Active Listening as a Tool for Higher-Order Thinking

Key RULE: If you know the answer to a Question - It is not open ended and does not evoke Higher -Order Thinking or Lateral Thinking

Active listening creates the conditions for higher-order thinking by:

- encouraging learners to articulate reasoning
- helping students clarify and refine ideas
- building confidence to take intellectual risks
- supporting deeper dialogue and inquiry
- Forces an adult to rephrase the question - where the answer is NOT KNOWN and possibilities are open

When students feel genuinely heard, they are more willing to engage with complex ideas, challenge assumptions, and revise their thinking.

Active Listening in Inquiry and Socratic Dialogue

In inquiry-led and Socratic approaches, active listening is essential.

Teachers listen in order to:

- identify underlying assumptions

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- notice patterns or misconceptions
- decide when to probe further
- choose questions that extend thinking rather than close it

The teacher's response is guided by what has been heard, not by a pre-planned answer.

Active Listening Across Learning Contexts

Active listening applies across:

- academic learning with ExelBots
- Quest-based discussions
- Innovation Hub collaboration
- reflection and mentoring conversations

In each context, listening informs professional judgement about pacing, challenge, support, and next steps.

Why Active Listening Matters

Active listening:

- strengthens student agency and confidence
- improves the quality of dialogue and questioning
- supports inclusion and equity
- enhances assessment for learning
- aligns with research on effective teaching and learning

At Edenbridge Grammar, active listening is understood as a **core teaching competency**, essential to creating learning environments where thinking is visible, valued, and developed.

In Practice during Quest and Applied Learning Sessions

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In Quest-based and applied learning sessions, Teachers, Guides and Mentors act primarily as **play partners, thinking partners, and challenge guides**.

In practice, this means teachers:

- design and build upon existing course outlines with rich tasks that allow multiple entry points and levels of challenge
- observe how students approach problems, collaborate, and think
- ask Open-ended questions that stretch reasoning and deepen reflection
- guide students to make connections between ideas and real-world contexts
- support productive struggle without removing challenge

Examples in Practice

Example 1:

A group of students is working on a Quest focused on solving a local community problem. Some students immediately begin proposing solutions, while others struggle to define the problem clearly.
The teacher does not give answers. Instead, they move between groups, asking questions such as:

- *What evidence do you have that this is the main problem?*
- *Who is affected, and how do you know?*
- *What is meaningful for you? What problems in your world do you care about?*

For one group, the teacher introduces a challenge by asking them to test their idea against a real-world constraint. For another, the teacher slows the process by helping them break the problem into smaller parts. Each group remains engaged, but at an appropriate level of challenge.

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Example 2:

During a design-focused Quest, one student dominates discussion while others remain quiet.

The Expert intervenes by reshaping roles within the group, encouraging quieter students to lead specific elements of the task. The Expert helps the student identify what their real skill is and how it will be vital in enabling the growth of the project. The Expert supports collaboration and thinking without taking control of the project.

In Summary: Teachers adjust their support in response to how students are engaging, thinking, and collaborating, rather than directing every step. Learning remains social, exploratory, and purpose driven.

In Practice during ExelBot-Supported Academic Learning

When students are working with ExelBots, teachers take on a complementary role focused on **guidance, oversight, and strategic support**.

In practice, this means teachers:

- support students in asking deeper questions and clarifying understanding
- guide effective study habits, time management, and learning strategies
- help students interpret feedback and decide on next steps
- support small-group or peer study sessions where appropriate
- monitor progress and identify patterns in understanding or difficult

Example in Practice

Example 1:
A student working with an ExelBot on a mathematics Concept Capsule is progressing quickly but making repeated small errors.
The teacher reviews the learner's feedback data and sits with the student briefly to discuss strategy, asking:

- *What do you notice about where mistakes are happening?*

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- *What could you slow down or check differently?*
- *What gaps might you have left in your Concept Capsule Progression that we need to go back and fill in some knowledge?*

The teacher helps the student adjust approach rather than repeating content.

Example 2:
Several students are working independently with ExelBots on different subjects. One student appears disengaged and stuck.
The teacher checks in, helping the student break the task into manageable steps and suggesting a short peer study session with another learner working on a similar concept.

In Summary: ExelBots provide personalised instruction and feedback, while Experts, Guides and Teachers ensure that learning remains purposeful, balanced, and aligned with broader goals.

Monitoring Progress and Supporting Reflection

Across both learning contexts, teachers play a central role in helping students reflect on and plan their learning journey.

This includes:

- reviewing evidence of progress across subjects and Quests - bringing the student into discussions on attainment, challenges, successes and goals
- supporting students to revisit goals set through Territory Mapping and revisiting, evaluating and realigning their own learning goals termly
- helping learners recognise and celebrate growth, challenges, and next priorities
- guiding students to set realistic, meaningful goals for the next phase of learning

In this way, responsiveness is not only about pace, but about helping learners develop awareness, confidence, and responsibility for their own progress.

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Teaching Practice

Curriculum planning and delivery, role of adult in 'real-time' and environment use to enhance deep and long-term learning

Across all phases, Innovation Hubs are designed to support applied, inquiry-led learning. However, this does not replace the academic curriculum, it enhances it. Teachers are responsible for ensuring that learning experiences and the environment they set up are strategically planning to drive students to learn the academic skills they know are to be learnt. Within each Hub we see **explicitly connected projects, experiences and learning spaces that are underpinned by curriculum intentions**.

These learning intentions are communicated to students, even from as young as 3 years old. We use 'I Can' statements to help students articulate 'WHAT' they are aiming to learn and describe the steps, outcomes, process and knowledge gained.

Students should always be able to answer the question:
"What am I learning, how and why?"

The nature of that answer evolves across the phases, reflecting the abilities and competencies of the students. This is the most Strategic Role that Teachers, Experts and Guides hold within Edenbridge Grammar.

NB: Research in cognitive development and learning science demonstrates that young children are capable of engaging with **highly complex**, even **university-level concepts** when these ideas are introduced through **developmentally appropriate, experiential, and play-based approaches.**

When sophisticated concepts are presented in **meaningful contexts**, learners draw on **existing knowledge, lived experience, and sensory interaction** to actively **construct understanding**. The brain is naturally driven to **resolve complexity**; it seeks **patterns, relationships, and coherence**, forming rich networks of **neural connections** rather than relying on rote memorisation.

This process enables **deep conceptual understanding** and **long-term transfer,** allowing learners to progress rapidly through curriculum pathways without being constrained by repetitive, low-level tasks. In such environments, **learning is accelerated** not through

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pressure, but through curiosity, relevance, and the natural human capacity to make sense of the unknown.

At Edenbridge Grammar, this research-informed understanding underpins our commitment to applied learning and challenge-driven learning as the foundation of our teaching and learning model.

By presenting learners with rich, meaningful challenges and complex ideas rooted in real contexts, we invite them to actively construct understanding rather than passively receive information. **Applied, challenge-driven experiences** enable students to connect new concepts to prior knowledge, lived experience, and purposeful action, activating deep cognitive engagement and sustained curiosity.

In this way, **learning is accelerated** through relevance and intellectual stretch, not repetition or memorisation. Our model recognises that when learners are trusted with complexity and supported through **thoughtful design, dialogue, and exploration**, they develop **robust understanding, transferable skills** and the **confidence** to progress well beyond traditional expectations while remaining grounded in joyful, developmentally appropriate learning.

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Below we break this down by Phase, in how it looks in practice.

Foundation Phase | Fitrah Phase

Curriculum Visibility in Play and Exploration

In the Foundation Phase, Innovation Hubs prioritise exploration, play, language, and early conceptual understanding. While learning may appear playful, it is always intentionally linked to curriculum goals.

Teachers are responsible for:

- identifying the specific curriculum objectives being addressed in each activity

- making learning intentions visible through language and clearly designed and set up 'learning spaces' that encourage projects, role-paly, discovery, early research and communication.

- 'ICAN' statements and prompts displayed in these learning spaces articulate clearly 'What is being learnt', learning goals and early challenges children are taking on.
    - These are drawn directly from Edenbridge Grammar's Curriculum *(Found here)

- Adults create reflection opportunities regularly, throughout the day, with small groups of children, while working and playing; where children articulate what they have learnt or are aiming to learn

- explicitly naming concepts during and after learning experiences

- Record, film, take pictures of and document evidence of the learning children have showcased. This is uploaded to each child's records and electronic portfolio of learning evidence

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For example, activities involving:

- **construction and materials** are linked to early science, design, and mathematics concepts such as properties, structure, measurement, and comparison.

- **storytelling and role-play** are linked to language development, sequencing, values and religion, communication, and early literacy

- **creative play and making** are linked to problem-solving, fine motor skills, and early reasoning

Ensure that each Learning Space has tables or clipboards for writing, sophisticated mathematic or scientific resources and technology tools (Computers, ipads, cameras etc), where appropriate, so students are linking big concepts to their play and exploration.

Teachers regularly refer back to the academic curriculum to ensure that:

- play-based experiences build required foundational knowledge
- That spaces are altered or built on in order to allow for and encourage the next steps in learning
- key vocabulary and concepts are introduced intentionally
- learning outcomes are clear, even when activities are open-ended

Reflection, discussion, and documentation are used to help students recognise what they have learned, not just what they have done.

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Foundation Phase:

Capturing Learning Through Guided Documentation

In the Foundation Phase, students may progress through aspects of the curriculum more quickly than traditionally expected. It is the responsibility of teachers to recognise and support this progress by actively capturing evidence of learning as it occurs.

At this stage, teachers take the lead in documenting learning. Using iPads, cameras, large floor books or learning portfolios. Adults record photographs, short videos, audio clips, or examples of children's work during play, exploration, and guided activities. This evidence may include construction models, storytelling, early writing or drawing, problem-solving activities, or demonstrations of understanding through talk and action.

Teachers upload this evidence to each child's digital portfolio within the ExelTutorBot or Quest space. This documentation helps make learning visible, supports assessment against curriculum objectives, and ensures that progress is recognised even when it occurs through play-based or applied experiences. Teachers also begin to model simple reflection by talking with children about what they have learned and celebrating growth in understanding.

The 'How to' of Questioning in This Phase

To build **curiosity, language, confidence, and early thinking habits**.

At this stage, questioning is not about analysis or critique. It is about helping children realise that **questions are welcome, safe, and valuable**.

How Questioning Looks in Practice

- Teachers model curiosity aloud: *"I wonder why…?" or "Would it be possible if…?" or "How do you see this changing if …"*

- Questions are generated orally, through play, talk, drawings, or role-play. Adults play alongside students, modelling explorative and investigative play…
    - *'Sometimes learners teach, sometimes teachers learn'*

- Children are encouraged to ask questions without needing to "get them right"

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Question focuses are concrete and familiar, such as:

- an object
- a picture
- a story
- a shared experience

Teacher Role

- Model asking questions
- Capture children's questions visually or orally
- Encourage all contributions
- Avoid correcting or evaluating questions

The emphasis is on **producing questions**, not refining them.



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The ‘Teaching’ part-

When do we plan to teach the complex concepts and information that needs to be instructed in order to learn or understand?

Foundation Phase: Teaching and Learning in Practice

In the Foundation Phase, teaching at Edenbridge Grammar is **intentional, relational, and carefully paced**. While exploration and play are central, they are supported by purposeful teaching moments that introduce key concepts, language, and ways of thinking.

Teaching in this phase is designed to **build understanding through experience**, not through extended instruction or task completion.

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Purposeful Teaching Through Play

In the Foundation Phase, much of the most effective teaching takes place through **guided play and real-world simulation**. Teachers plan bespoke learning experiences where children are supported to explore concepts through meaningful, imaginative activity.

Teaching often happens:

- in small groups
- one-to-one
- within carefully prepared play environments

For example in learning Mathematic Concepts:

- a teacher may guide children in helping dolls spend a set amount of money in a pretend shop, introducing early ideas of number, value, choice, and comparison

- a teacher may support children in sharing spots evenly across a family of ladybirds, exploring early concepts of equality, grouping, and total

In these moments, the teacher:

- introduces precise language and knowledge detail
- asks guiding questions
- models thinking aloud
- responds to children's ideas and reasoning

The focus is on understanding, not speed or correctness.

Short, Focused Group Teaching Sessions

Alongside play-based learning, children participate in **two short group teaching sessions each day**, each lasting no more than ten minutes.

These sessions are designed to:

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- introduce new ideas
- build shared language and understanding
- spark curiosity

They may focus on areas such as:

- early mathematics
- sounds, words, and language
- science and the natural world
- geography and understanding place

These sessions are **informational and invitational**, not task-driven. Children are not expected to complete worksheets or produce outcomes immediately. Instead, ideas introduced in these sessions are revisited naturally through play, stories, discussion, and exploration across the day.

Stories and Literature as the Spine of Learning

Edenbridge Grammar is a **story and literature-led school**, particularly in the Foundation Phase.

Stories run throughout the learning day and serve multiple purposes:

- developing language and listening skills
- expanding imagination and emotional understanding
- introducing concepts, vocabulary, and cultural knowledge
- supporting reflection and meaning-making

Teachers carefully select rich texts, traditional stories, and high-quality literature. Stories are revisited, retold, acted out, discussed, and extended through play, art, and conversation.

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Story is treated not as a break from learning, but as a **primary vehicle for learning**.

The Role of the Teacher in the Foundation Phase

In this phase, teachers act as:

- **instructors through play**
- **Facilitators of thought**
- **Modelling knowledge, ideas and exploration skills**
- **storytellers and readers**
- **observers of emerging understanding**
- **guides who introduce language and concepts at the right moment**
- **A challenge guide, presenting new and complex concepts**

Teachers are responsible for:

- planning teaching moments in advance
- Setting up strategically designed learning spaces
- noticing when children are ready for new ideas
- capturing evidence of learning through observation, photographs, and dialogue
- helping children reflect on what they have discovered

Teaching is responsive and deliberate, always grounded in children's development and curiosity.

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Why This Approach Matters

This approach ensures that:

- children build strong conceptual foundations
- learning feels joyful, meaningful, and safe
- teaching is visible without being overwhelming
- early academic understanding develops naturally and securely

By combining guided play, short focused teaching, and rich storytelling, the Foundation Phase supports children to develop confidence, curiosity, and a love of learning that will carry forward into later phases.

Formation Phase: Tazkiyah Phase

Strengthening Curriculum Coherence Through Application

In the Formation Phase, Learning spaces remain and are strategically planned to increasingly reflect even more complex real-world contexts and applied challenges. Academic learning becomes even more explicit, and connections between subjects are strengthened.

Teachers are responsible for:

- Planning learning spaces or experiences that directly align with subject-specific curriculum objectives
- Design spaces to be ‘cross-curricular’ and project focused, so students have a long-term challenge to complete and clear goals to achieve, underpinned by academic learning goals.
- ensuring that applied tasks and long-term projects reinforce key academic concepts

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- supporting students to articulate links between what they are doing and what they are learning

For example:

- a design or investigation task is explicitly linked to science concepts, mathematical reasoning and/or humanities knowledge
- A drama being created are connected to reading, writing, and the arts
- An ECO and Vegetable growing project is connected to research skills, literacy, science, geography and communication concepts
- collaborative tasks are used to deepen understanding, not replace academic content

Teachers continually reference the academic curriculum to confirm that:

- required knowledge and skills are being developed
- progression remains coherent and cumulative
- applied learning strengthens, rather than dilutes, subject understanding

Shared Responsibility for Evidence and Reflection

In the Formation Phase, students continue to progress at different rates, and evidence of learning becomes more varied and explicit. Teachers remain responsible for ensuring that progress through the curriculum is accurately documented, while gradually introducing students to the process of capturing and reflecting on their own learning.

Teachers continue to record and upload evidence of learning, including project work, investigations, written outcomes, practical tasks, and collaborative activities. At the same time, students are supported to begin contributing to their own portfolios, for example by selecting pieces of work to upload, recording short reflections, or explaining achievements with guidance.

Teachers explicitly teach students how to:

- recognise when learning is worth capturing

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- explain what they have learned and why it matters
- understand that portfolios are a record of growth, not perfection

This shared approach ensures that evidence of attainment and progress is consistently recorded, while supporting students to develop early ownership of their learning journey.

The "How to' of Questioning in This Phase

To help learners move from curiosity to **clarity, reasoning, and explanation**.

Students begin to understand that different questions lead to different kinds of thinking.

How Questioning Looks in Practice

- Students generate multiple questions about a topic or problem
- Teachers introduce the idea of **open and closed questions**
- Students practise changing one type of question into another
- Questions are used to guide research, discussion, or investigation

Question focuses may include:

- a problem statement
- a real-world scenario
- a short text or data set
- a scientific or social phenomenon

Teacher Role

- Introduce simple structures for improving questions
- Support students in selecting useful questions
- Help learners link questions to academic content

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- Encourage explanation and justification

The emphasis is on **improving and using questions** to deepen understanding.

The Teaching Part:

This is one of the most important phases within Edenbridge Grammar. In traditional education models, we either **cap children too early** or **push them unsafely**. We do neither. Edenbridge Grammar's teaching model is a *carefully choreographed transition* between playful exploration and sophisticated academic thought.

Formation Phase: Teaching and Learning in Practice

The Formation Phase represents a critical bridge in the Edenbridge Grammar framework. Learners are no longer early years children, yet they are not expected to begin to use the AI teaching modality solely at this age- that will be more appealing and more easily accessed by those of 10 years on up. Teaching in this phase requires **professional judgement, intentional planning, and flexibility**.

Students in the **Formation Phase** are capable of progressing well beyond traditional age-based expectations, particularly when learning is rooted in experiential and applied contexts. Many learners may engage with early secondary concepts by the age of nine and, in some cases, access knowledge typically associated with much later stages of schooling. However, while the level of understanding may be advanced, the ways in which learners explore, express, and demonstrate their knowledge will often remain developmentally appropriate, playful, and child-centred.

The role of the teacher in this phase is to **hold the tension** between play, exploration, and increasingly sophisticated academic input. Our AI Tutors may serve as a teaching tool to some who show interest and aptitude for this style of learning, yet others may thrive more through project based and teacher taught style of learning. The 'dance' between the two will challenge adults in this phase to strike the right balance. Therefore learning the skills and teaching model outlined below is **essential.**

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Intentional Teaching: Raising the Academic Ceiling

In the Formation Phase, teachers continue to use play, exploration, and applied contexts as vehicles for learning. However, the **level of content introduced increases significantly**.

Teaching and Strategically designed 'Learning Spaces' remain:

- carefully planned
- Resource rich
- Linked to real-world contexts and outcome driven *(solving real-world problems or creating something that lasts)
- responsive to readiness
- grounded in meaningful contexts

Teachers are expected to draw intentionally from **upper-stage curricula**, selecting key concepts, vocabulary, and ideas and making them accessible through age-appropriate experiences.

For example:

- a construction activity may introduce concepts from secondary-level physics, such as forces, balance, or load
- a storytelling project may include advanced narrative structure, perspective, or ethical themes
- A tech or IT project may include the challenge to develop their own website or play-station game, pulling on coding, technical, mathematical concepts from university or A Level knowledge base.
- a real-world simulation may incorporate early algebraic thinking, proportional reasoning, or systems thinking

The aim is not to accelerate superficially, but to **deepen understanding** through thoughtful translation of complex ideas.

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Bespoke Teaching Through Play and Application

Teaching in the Formation Phase often takes place through **bespoke, small-group or one-to-one instruction**, embedded within meaningful activity.

Teachers may:

- introduce advanced ideas during hands-on tasks
- **Just Knowledge sessions:** Daily teaching bursts, where most of the class is listening to 13-15 minutes of instruction or explanation of a complex concept - with no expectations for workbook or task work after.
    - Teachers must ensure that experiences and opportunities for students to rehearse, embed and deepen knowledge of these taught concepts are available within the learning environment
- use precise academic language while maintaining playful engagement
- revisit complex concepts across multiple contexts and gather evidence of understanding. If not evident, revise, redesign and re-present in a new way.
- slow learning down when depth is required, even as the ceiling remains high
- 80% of the learning day, students are engaged in 'Applied Learning'

This approach allows learners to engage with sophisticated knowledge without losing curiosity, confidence, or joy.

Short, Focused Group Teaching Sessions

As in the Foundation Phase, learners participate in **two short whole-group teaching moments per day**, each lasting no more than ten minutes.

In the Formation Phase, these sessions:

- introduce higher-level academic ideas

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- expose learners to rich language and concepts
- seed thinking that will later be explored in depth

These sessions may draw from:

- upper primary and early secondary mathematics
- science and geography concepts
- historical or cultural knowledge
- disciplinary ways of thinking

These sessions are not followed by worksheets or compulsory tasks. Instead, they act as **intellectual invitations**, allowing learners to encounter advanced ideas without pressure to immediately master them.

Stories and Literature as Vehicles for Sophisticated Thinking

Story and literature remain central in the **Formation Phase**, but texts become richer, more complex, and more demanding.

Teachers use literature to:

- introduce abstract ideas
- explore moral and ethical questions
- develop advanced language and comprehension
- connect emotional understanding to intellectual growth

Stories are revisited, discussed, questioned, and connected to learning across subjects. Literature becomes a **bridge between imagination and academic depth**.

Curriculum Awareness and Intentional Planning

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Teachers in the Formation Phase must work with **multiple curriculum levels simultaneously**.

This includes:

- awareness of early years foundations
- fluency in upper primary expectations
- selective use of early secondary concepts

Teachers plan learning using:

- clear learning intentions
- explicit ICAN statements
- intentional selection of concepts from higher curricula

This ensures that learning remains coherent, purposeful, and visible, even as students move at different speeds.

The Professional Challenge of the Formation Phase

The Formation Phase requires a genuine professional "dance" between:

- play and precisio
- curiosity and challenge
- safety and ambition
- joy and rigour

Teachers are expected to:

- notice readiness rather than rely on age
- maintain high expectations without pressure

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- protect emotional wellbeing alongside intellectual stretch
- collaborate closely with colleagues

This is one of the most demanding phases to teach well, and Edenbridge Grammar recognises the skill and care required.



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Orientation and Direction Phases: Teaching and Learning in Practice

The Orientation and Direction Phases represent a fundamental shift in the teaching and learning model at Edenbridge Grammar. While academic rigour remains central, the structure, roles, and learning rhythms evolve significantly to reflect learners' increasing independence, capability, and sense of purpose.

Learning in these phases is organised through an **80–20 split model**, combining personalised academic study with deep, applied, challenge-driven learning. Together, these phases support learners to move from guided self-awareness toward confident ownership of learning, skills, and future pathways.

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The 80–20 Split Learning Model

20% Academic Learning: ExelTutorBot-Supported Study

Approximately 20% of the learning week is dedicated to focused academic study supported by
ExelTutor Bots. This time is **structured, intentional** and **highly personalised**.

Students have two clear pathways within this academic study time:

Option 1: Broad, Balanced Progression
Students may choose to work across four or five subjects over the course of a week, engaging with two or three subjects per day. This supports steady, systematic progression through the curriculum, similar in structure to more traditional models, but with far greater flexibility, personalisation, and control of pace, due to the AI Tutor Bot platform.

Option 2: Deep Subject Immersion
Alternatively, students may choose to focus intensively on a single subject, or a small cluster of related subjects, for a defined period (for example, one to three weeks). This allows learners with strong interest or aptitude to progress rapidly, reaching high levels of mastery without unnecessary repetition.

ExelTutorBots track progress continuously, recording what has been learned, what requires consolidation, and where learners are ready to advance.

20% Academic Learning: The role of the adult: Teacher/ Expert/ or Guide

During ExelTutorBot-supported learning, teachers act as **academic mentors and progress guides**, not primary instructors.

Their responsibilities include:

- monitoring student progress through back-office systems
- supporting students to plan subject choices and pacing
- ensuring reasonable curriculum coverage over time
- guiding goal-setting through Territory Mapping

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- supporting learners to balance strengths with breadth
- intervening where students avoid challenge or neglect key areas

Teachers meet with students regularly (at least termly) to review progress, reflect on learning patterns, and agree next steps. Academic freedom is deliberately balanced with responsibility and oversight.

80% Applied Learning: Innovation Hubs and Expert-Led Quests

The remaining 80% of learning time is dedicated to **applied, challenge-driven learning** within Innovation Hubs.

In these phases, adults move decisively away from a traditional teaching role and into the role of **domain experts, facilitators, and intellectual guides**.

Innovation Hubs and Areas of Expertise

Each Innovation Hub is organised around a real-world domain. Examples include:

- enterprise, entrepreneurship, and business growth
- financial literacy and economic understanding
- technology, coding, AI, and digital design
- sustainability, regenerative earth, health, and agriculture
- arts, literature, communication, and drama
- digital media, platforms, and communication

(Additional hubs will be present and exist in specific school contexts or as the needs of the world alter.)

Each hub is led by an **Expert** with deep knowledge and experience in that domain.

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The Role of the Expert

Experts are responsible for:

- facilitating Quest-based applied learning
- guiding students through complex, real-world challenges
- deepening and extending existing Quest curricula
- designing new Quests where appropriate
- modelling professional thinking and problem-solving
- using questioning to stretch, challenge, and refine thinking
- supporting purposeful use of AI tools
- guiding portfolio development and evidence curation
- supporting credit accumulation across skills such as collaboration, leadership, project management, academic topics and communication

Experts act as **questioners, facilitators, and intellectual provocateurs**, supporting learners to move from ideas to viable solutions and from activity to insight.

Quests, AI, and Evidence of Learning

Applied learning Quests are already designed within the Edenbridge Grammar curriculum. Experts are encouraged to:

- adapt Quests to local context
- extend depth and complexity
- respond to student interest and emerging challenges

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Students use AI-supported ExelQuest platform to:

- research and test ideas
- model solutions
- refine thinking
- document learning
- gather evidence for portfolios
- Get tips and advice and guidance on how to complete tasks, develop tools and so much more

Experts ensure that applied learning remains rigorous, reflective, and purposeful.

Cross-Phase Learning and Co-Learning

Experts typically work across both the Orientation and Direction Phases. This enables:

- continuity of expertise
- mentoring relationships over time
- flexible grouping based on readiness and interest
- opportunities for cross-phase collaboration

Students may work alongside peers from different phases where appropriate, supporting peer learning, leadership, and knowledge transfer.

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Orientation Phase Specific: Skills, Identity, and Guided Ownership

In the Orientation Phase, Innovation Hubs are fully Quest-centred. While academic learning continues through subjects and ExelTutor Bots, teachers and experts place greater emphasis on helping learners understand **how they learn** and **what skills they are developing**.

Teachers are responsible for:

- explicitly linking Quest activities to the **skills and learning matrix**
- supporting students to recognise growth in collaboration, problem-solving, communication, and self-management
- helping learners reflect on strengths, challenges, and learning strategies
- delivering short, planned skill-focused inputs required for Quest success

Examples include:

- *What is a Customer Avatar?* (Entrepreneurship Quest)
- *How do I research regional purchasing or dietary trends?* (Regenerative Earth Quest)

Academic knowledge remains explicit. Teachers support learners to:

- articulate non-academic (soft skill) goals
- rehearse and consolidate academic knowledge gained through ExelTutor Bots
- connect Quest achievements to progress and attainment through Territory Mapping
- understand how skills transfer across contexts

Increasing Student Ownership of Evidence and Progress (Orientation Phase)

In the Orientation Phase, responsibility for documenting learning increasingly shifts toward the learner.

Students are supported to:

- capture and upload evidence of academic, applied, and skills-based learning

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Teachers guide this process by:

- supporting selection of appropriate evidence
- teaching how to upload work, presentations, reflections, and artefacts
- linking evidence to curriculum and skills matrices
- supporting reflection and next-step planning

Teachers continue to monitor portfolios to ensure quality, alignment, and accuracy, while intentionally building student independence.

The 'How to' in Questioning in the Orientation Phase

Questioning supports **self-awareness, critical thinking, and purposeful learning**.

In practice:

- students independently generate and prioritise questions
- questions drive Quests and inquiry
- learners reflect on which questions led to deeper understanding
- questioning is linked to Territory Mapping and goal-setting

Teachers:

- facilitate structured dialogue and reflection
- challenge assumptions respectfully
- encourage multiple perspectives
- help learners connect questioning to skills development

The emphasis is on using questions to guide **learning choices and identity development**.

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Direction Phase Specific: Pathways, Mastery, and Learner-Led Ownership

In the Direction Phase, Innovation Hubs are fully Quest-centred and explicitly aligned to future pathways. Learning becomes more self-directed, specialised, and purposeful. Some learners may still be completing aspects of their academic curriculum and will continue to use ExelTutorBots to consolidate and evidence subject mastery.

Others may have completed this phase of their academic journey and will increasingly focus on advanced application, extended research, and real-world leadership. This may include running and scaling student-led businesses or ventures, mentoring younger learners, engaging with university-level concepts and research, contributing to curriculum or Quest development, and taking on meaningful roles within the school community related to innovation, research, or enterprise.

At this stage, learning is characterised by depth, responsibility, interests or goals and contribution, as learners move beyond participation toward impact while continuing to develop expertise within their chosen domains.

Teachers and Experts are responsible for:

- guiding learners to align academic learning, applied projects, and skills development with long-term goals
- ensuring evidence reflects both subject mastery and transferable capabilities
- supporting learners to curate portfolios demonstrating readiness for further study, work, or entrepreneurship
- Signposting learners to further learning opportunities, universities or apprenticeships

Teachers explicitly reference academic and skills matrices to ensure that:

- learning remains balanced and credible
- learners can articulate what they know and what they can do
- progression decisions are informed and defensible

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Learner-Led Documentation and Portfolio Curation (Direction Phase)

Students take primary responsibility for documenting and curating their learning journey.

Students independently upload:

- academic work and assessments
- Quest outcomes and project evidence
- presentations, prototypes, and research
- reflective commentary on growth

Teachers act as **mentors and quality guides**, ensuring evidence is:

- appropriately selected
- clearly linked to curriculum and skills matrices
- representative of depth, not just activity

Portfolios become outward-facing records for universities, examination centres, employers, and future partners.

The 'How to' on Questioning in the Direction Phase

Questioning becomes a **strategic, lifelong thinking tool**.

Students:

- formulate sophisticated, discipline-specific questions
- use questioning to guide extended research and specialisation
- critique and refine their own questions
- prepare for higher education, work, and civic leadership

Teachers:

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- act as mentors and intellectual sounding boards
- support rigour and depth
- ensure alignment with academic and skills matrices
- support articulation of learning to external audiences

Making Learning Explicit Across All Phases

Across all Innovation Hubs and phases, adults are expected to:

- name learning intentions clearly
- refer regularly to curriculum objectives and skills matrices
- support reflection on both process and outcome
- ensure applied learning remains anchored in clear educational purpose

Innovation Hubs therefore **enhance curriculum delivery rather than obscure it**, ensuring learning remains both meaningful and academically robust.

Connected to Real-World Meaning and Application

Learning is more powerful and enduring when students understand **why it matters**. At Edenbridge Grammar, knowledge is not treated as abstract or disconnected from life beyond school. Instead, learning is intentionally connected to real-world contexts, challenges, and applications.

In practice, this means:

- linking academic ideas to real-world examples, current issues, and authentic problems
- designing applied learning through projects and Quests that require students to use knowledge purposefully

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- encouraging learners to see how disciplines such as mathematics, science, language, technology, and humanities operate in real professions and communities
- helping students understand not only *what* they are learning, but *why* it is useful and *how* it can be applied

Teachers support students to make these connections explicit through discussion, reflection, and application. This approach strengthens motivation, deepens understanding, and supports long-term retention by anchoring learning in relevance and meaning.

Many Quest curriculums are written, yet they are designed to be generic in parts, in order to give capacity for students and teachers to personalise them to the country they are living in or specific needs of specific communities or cultures.

Use of Technology in Learning

Technology, including AI-enabled tools, is used at Edenbridge Grammar to **enhance learning, not replace teaching**. Digital tools support personalisation, feedback, and access to complex knowledge in ways that would be difficult to achieve through traditional methods alone.

Technology supports learning by:

- enabling students to practise and revisit concepts at an appropriate pace
- providing timely, targeted feedback
- allowing learners to access advanced knowledge when ready
- supporting documentation and reflection through digital portfolios
- Helping students gain true maturity, agency and knowledge in how best to utilise AI and tech

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Teachers remain central to the learning process. Their role is essential in:

- interpreting student progress and patterns of learning
- supporting understanding, motivation, and confidence
- connecting learning to wider goals, applied contexts, and future pathways
- caring for students' wellbeing and emotional readiness

Technology is treated as an **amplifier of good teaching**, not a substitute for professional judgement, relationships, or care.

Professional Reflection and Growth

Teaching at Edenbridge Grammar is understood as a **developing professional practice**, not a fixed set of methods. Educators are expected to engage in ongoing reflection, learning, and collaboration in order to meet the evolving needs of learners.

Teachers are expected to:

- reflect regularly on what is working well and what needs adjustment
- respond thoughtfully to student progress, feedback, and emerging needs
- collaborate with colleagues to share practice, problem-solve, and improve consistency
- engage in ongoing professional learning aligned with the Edenbridge Grammar framework
- Add their ideas and professional knowledge to the CPD bank, adding to the continuous learning and reflective practice ethos of ExelAacademy.

This approach fosters a shared culture of professionalism, openness, and continuous improvement. Reflection is viewed not as self-criticism, but as a core professional responsibility that strengthens teaching quality and learner outcomes over time.

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Appendix 1

Teacher Active Listening Self-Assessment

Active Listening Self-Assessment Checklist for Teachers

Purpose:
This checklist supports teachers in reflecting on how effectively they listen to students' thinking in order to deepen understanding, confidence, and higher-order learning.

It is not a judgement tool. It is a guide for professional growth.

---

1. Mindset and Intent

I approach student responses with curiosity, not evaluation.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I assume that student answers contain meaning, even when they are unclear or incomplete.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I value how students are thinking as much as whether the answer is correct.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I am comfortable allowing silence or thinking time without rushing to intervene.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

---

2. Listening Behaviours in the Classroom

I allow students to finish explaining their ideas without interrupting.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I use body language, eye contact, and positioning to show full attention.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I paraphrase or reflect back what students say to check understanding.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

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I listen to the *reasoning behind* an answer, not just the answer itself.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

---

3. Questioning and Response

My follow-up questions build directly on what the student has said.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I avoid correcting students immediately when their thinking is incomplete.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I use prompts such as *"Tell me more"*, *"What makes you think that?"*, or *"Can you explain your thinking?"*
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I resist the urge to rephrase a student's idea too quickly in my own words.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

---

4. Active Listening in Inquiry and Dialogue

I listen for assumptions, patterns, or misconceptions before responding.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I allow student ideas to shape the direction of discussion where appropriate.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I encourage students to respond to one another, not only to me.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I treat disagreement and uncertainty as opportunities for learning.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

---

5. Reflection and Professional Growth

After lessons, I reflect on how listening influenced student thinking.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

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I notice patterns in who speaks and who remains quiet.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I actively work to include all learners' voices.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

I seek feedback or discussion with colleagues about my listening practices.
☐ Consistently ☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Rarely

Optional Reflection Prompts

Teachers may choose one prompt for short written or verbal reflection:

- *When did I listen most effectively today?*
- *How did my listening influence student confidence or depth of thinking?*
- *Where did I intervene too quickly, and what might I try next time?*
- *Which students' thinking do I need to hear more clearly?*

Using This Checklist Well

This checklist is most effective when used:

- briefly and regularly

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- alongside lesson reflection

- as part of coaching or mentoring conversations

- during peer observation (with shared language and trust)

Active listening is not a fixed trait. It is a **professional skill that develops through awareness and practice**.

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